

The infamous 1896 “separate, but equal” ruling of *Plessy v. Ferguson* upheld the constitutionality of racial segregation, utilizing the doctrine to thwart the intent of the Fourteenth Amendment. African Americans in particular had by now realized that the progress they so desperately sought had withered away with the beginning of the new segregatory era. This served as a stark reminder to African Americans that the whites still had power and tools of subjugation apart from a whip. The subjugation of non-white peoples, however, was not limited to the domestic population. At the turn of the twentieth century, American exceptionalism coupled with racist ideologies pushed the U.S. to expand its doctrine of manifest destiny past the borders of its contiguous states. Consistent with the limited liberties of the non-white population at home, imperialists sought to undermine the independence of the majority-colored island of Cuba just two years after the U.S.’s implicit, judicial declaration of legal inferiority. Cuba’s proximity, laying 90 miles off the coast of Florida, made it a near-perfect participant in the experiment of American expansion. Imperialists and anti-imperialists alike utilized the United States’ domestic racial conflict and ideologies to bolster their own Cuban foreign policy propositions, in nearly all cases demeaning black Cubans and black Americans. The United States’ expansion into the country extended not just their American democratic values, but also their white-supremacist ideologies, intimidating, dehumanizing, and oppressing the colored population in both places.

The U.S. expansion of racism into Cuba did not simply target non-whites with white superiority and aggression but also spread the concept of African American inferiority. There was a portion of the black community who believed the independence of nonwhites in another country was not of their concern but a considerable amount of black Americans supported the

independence of Cuba. Its large nonwhite population reminded those racially oppressed in the U.S. of themselves and they wanted to support their freedom (gatewood). The African-American support was not always well received. Both the *Atlanta Constitution* and the *New York Times* detailed a plan in which black families were meant to be sent to Cuba. Amid the Spanish-American War, a Baptist clergyman had meant to send 30 negro families to Santiago, a ‘scheme’ met with avid opposition by black and white Cubans who were supposedly “anxious that only white immigrants shall come to Cuba”. Even more surprising was the assertion that “the Cuban negroes are even more bitter than the whites in denouncing the movement.” No more information could be found on this incident nor the reason this priest had decided to start a colony in Cuba at the birth of their independence. The *New York Times* article referred to a Hispanic newspaper titled *El Porvenir* as the original source for its’ article. In it, they reason that African Americans are “frequently guilty of horrible crimes” and the south was trying to get rid of the people that plagued it by sending them to Cuba. While there is no way to confirm the reliability of these claims of displaced Cubans, the preceding theme of “white only” was similar to the United States in both restrictive immigratory practices and racial preference. The bias towards white immigrants and refusal to allow African Americans into Cuba displayed the success of an imperialized racial system that would uplift the white minority while oppressing and discriminating against the black majority. The black Cubans that rejected the idea of an African American influx were the same as those refused immigrants in the eyes of white Americans: inferior and racially displeasing.

Nonetheless, the general disrespect and intimidation of the Cuban people of color mirrored the treatment of black Americans. One of the most infamous practitioners of racial

intimidation was Theodore Roosevelt, a staunch imperialist and supporter of the war in the face of, what he considered, the barbarism of Puerto Rico, Hawaiian, Cuban, and the Philippines. Roosevelt's mockery of these civilizations was rooted in racism, stating, "it is only the warlike power of a civilized people that can give peace to the world." (merriam). His concept of white superiority was not reserved for the perceived savages of these islands but was an extension of the systemic discriminatory practices and negative perception of non-whites in the United States. When Roosevelt had served in Cuba, there was an incident in which he threatened men of a black calvary after he had mistakenly thought they were retreating to the backline. Upon realizing this mistake, he acknowledged his ignorance, yet years later recalled the incident in a published account as a heroic act of preventing defection from the lazy black troops "dependent on white leadership". While this particular act of racial aggression was pointed towards black Americans, the perception of colored soldiers as incompetent was also pointed towards the Cubans. One soldier, who explicitly demonstrated the importance of Cubans and Africans, stated "the rebels were a lot of degenerates, absolutely devoid of honor or gratitude, no more capable of self-government than the savages of Africa." General John Brooke agreed, stating "The Cubans are utterly irresponsible and have no idea what good government is. Under our supervision and with firm and honest care for the future, the people of Cuba may become a useful ace." As usual, the Cubans were insulted and brushed aside as military and political players in their own country. The shared experiences of African-Americans and black Cubans at the hands of white Americans spoke to the export of racial intimidation and discrimination to the conquered island.

The American imperialists who set their eyes on Cuba often defended their conquest as a mission of uplifting third world countries who could not do it themselves, convincing many

American citizens that the United States had not just a duty as a democratic defender, but also as a humble humanitarian (Hoganson Part one). This heroic motivation, however, often perpetuated the dehumanization of the Cuban people as inferior and politically incapable to rule themselves. Louis Meikle had resented the involvement of the United States in the global south, adamantly protesting the imperial ventures of the United States. To Meikle, one of the biggest reasons the annexation of the West Indies should be opposed is the American emphasis on whiteness. "You must be white to be truthful and honest. You must be white to hold any position of trust outside of the political realm; and more than all, the American white man is rated, in the United States, at a higher premium than any other member of the Caucasian race, and so it is wherever the Stars and Stripes float as the controlling power," he contended. Meikle contends that U.S. expansion meant the overpowering of those native to the small countries to which they expanded and argued that they had already "assumed the position of official masters" in Cuba and the other islands of Hawaii, Puerto Rico, and the Philippines. For others, however, this white domination was a positive rather than a negative. Rudyard Kipling, despite his British nationality, invoked the U.S. spirit of white saviorism in his infamous poem *The White Man's Burden*. Reprinted hundreds of times in the U.S. and written in response to America's conquest of the Philippines on the other side of the globe, its message held true for most of the imperialist ventures at the beginning of the twentieth century. Kipling urges the selfless and humble white population to sacrifice their best and brightest to aid, educate, and uplift savage peoples. This blatantly racist call to action pushed to infantilize a regarded lesser people as children in need of white American salvation, simultaneously stripping them of their humanity and bolstering the argument that independence for these types of people was infeasible.

Much of the policy introduced regarding Cuba and the other islands garnered varying degrees of opinion from pro-imperialists and anti-imperialists alike, but it was the policymakers, Congress, who accepted Kipling's call to action and effectively oppressed the Cuban people. The oppression of Cuba was felt during the four-year period that the U.S. occupied the island and for the following years after the US had trapped Cuba into agreeing to the overbearing Platt amendment. The United States' "self-righteous disregard for the rights and sensibilities of small nations," (Paterson) was quite blatant and stemmed from the majority presence of black people on the island believed to be incapable of ruling themselves in Cuba the same as the black people who were incapable of ruling themselves in the United States. In 1897, McKinley in his message to the House and Senate discussed the problem of Cuban involvement, specifically whether or not the U.S. should step into the war between Spain and Cuba and what this would entail. He acknowledged the pro-imperialist argument of intervening on humanitarian grounds, and after "most anxious and earnest consideration" rejected the idea of involvement. McKinley reasoned that Spain had recently installed a new government meant to reverse the years of subjugation and cruelty invoked on Cuba and their other lands. McKinley stated, "if it shall hereafter appear to be a *duty* imposed by our obligations to ourselves, to civilization and humanity to intervene with force, it shall be without fault on our part and only because the necessity for such action will be so clear." Whether or not Spain's new government would keep their word was something time could tell, and until then the Cubans were to be left alone. However, the Cuban and Spanish conflict continued for months with no observable changes from Spain and no intervention from the United States. Only when the USS Maine was sunk did they feel necessary to uphold their "duty" to humanity and civilization, only intervening in the war to free them from Spain before

imprisoning the Cubans themselves. In this way, the repetitive arguments of humanitarian duty by imperialists in Congress were hardly a reason for U.S. expansion, but an excuse.

Helping the Cubans was not the main reason the United States had imperialized the country, and while there were many people who believed that going into Cuba would genuinely improve the country, it was likely based on the racist belief that, as a black majority country, they could not help themselves. Any Cuban who may have stated otherwise could be met with accusations of ungratefulness. In a 1900 Washington Post article, one imperialist published his disbelief of the Cubans.

“After our country, out of pure sympathy, has spent millions upon millions of treasure and sacrificed many of her noble sons upon the altar of humanity to rescue the Gem of the Antilles from Spanish greed and oppression, we are now called upon to give up all and retire from the field of action so that a hungry horde may reap what we have sown. And must we give the government over to men who have never received one lesson in the intricate school of civil affairs? . . . The amazing impudence . . . to demand immediate independence is unparalleled in all history . . . We are dealing with base men, devoid of magnanimity, and we must give them to understand that we have fathomed their true nature.” (eui)

This pro imperialist’s own reasoning that the United States intervened out of pure sympathy to save them from oppression contradicts his following claim that the United States should not have to leave Cuba after doing exactly what they supposedly went there to do. Ironically, many Americans conveniently disregarded their own, very similar, revolutionary past while simultaneously disregarding the Cubans. Cuba was also a small country in the hands of a world power that received help from another world power to gain its independence, yet for some reason, the Cubans could not govern themselves as the white-led United States had a century earlier. Anything hinting at the racist disregard for the Cuban people’s independence could be expunged by the claim of benevolent aid by the United States, allowing the U.S. to imperialize at

its heart's content under the guise of warped humanitarianism. The government and pro-imperialists of the United States' emphasis on duty to humanity highlighted the vulnerability of the Cuban people and expanded the perception of them as weak and incapable.

The United States further demonstrated their disregard for the Cuban people and mistrust in their abilities when they promised independence after the Spanish had been beaten, but were slow to hand over full control to the Cubans. United States' economic motivations intertwined with their racist ones as the perception of the Cuban people as racially inferior and relatively unimportant provided justification for the domination of the island. The U.S. exclusion of the Cubans from treaty discussions and immediate military occupation of the island demonstrated this best. Even when the United States had decided that Cuban occupation was no longer necessary or valuable, they still refused to release the island from their influence and diplomatic control. The passing of the Platt Amendment was a clear indicator that the U.S. did not believe that Cuba was ready to govern itself and although it loosened its grip on Cuba, it still held an immense amount of power. The Platt amendment guaranteed that the U.S. could intervene in Cuba for a variety of reasons with little to no specifics included. Among the articles of the amendment was the installment of U.S. coaling stations, prohibition of Cuba to make treaties with any other country that would impair Cuban independence, and gave the U.S. the right to intervene if their independence or democracy was threatened. The Platt amendment's vague allowances benefited the U.S. more than they did Cuba and were a constitutional extension of the racist policies that created an uneven power distribution between the two countries. Some Cubans were aware of this, such as Senor Juan Gomez, a member apart of the Cuban constitutional convention who gave a speech against accepting the Platt amendment. He

passionately stated that he would “rather be under the sovereignty of Spain...than that of the United States” as the “black blood in his veins made him opposed to Americans.” He was not ignorant to the American treatment of black people and had probably already witnessed the discrimination of his fellow Cubans or thought to expect it as long as Cuba was involved so heavily with the United States. Gomez made clear that the United States was not a friend to have and demanded the Platt amendment be rejected. Gomez’s objection to the U.S was indicative of the United States’ racial oppression that challenged that of Spain.

The United States’ sanctimonious grasp on Cuba was fostered by the white supremacist and overall racist ideologies that had plagued the United States since its creation. Cuba, while not quite familiar with intense racial conflict, was familiar with being oppressed by a first-world power. The United States had discriminated against and treated Cubans with disrespect that was reflective of the civil rights struggle of African-Americans. The same country that had helped fight for Cuba’s independence invoked on Cuba unfair policies rooted in their belief that the majority non-white population were incapable to rule. For white imperialists, the idea that a country with such a great amount of non-white people could govern itself was inconceivable at the time, leading to implicit racial conflict between the U.S. and Cuba. While the United States did not violently oppress them the same ways the Spanish did, they subjugated the Cubans politically and socially, instilling the racist American ideologies and withholding from the Cubans their own country. The promised independence of the Cubans was prolonged by U.S. occupation and intervention for years to come, exemplifying the racial consequence of United States imperialism.